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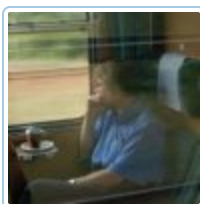
Music Corner

## Popularity as a measure of musical quality?

Discussion in 'Music Corner' started by Jazzis, Sep 8, 2005.

Thread Status: **Not open for further replies.**

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**Jazzis**

Forum Resident

Thread Starter

Location:

Israel

I wander what you think about that?

I have always felt a musical "freak" to some extent when chasing obscure and totally unpopular music, finding it the most challenging, meaningful and intellectually rewarding. My collection includes thousands of titles, which are rare and unfamiliar to most other people - and yet I consider them "better" musically then all the "popular" stuff.

If a million people like a piece of music, does it mean it is "good" music?

Can music be measured or compared at all? Are there any criteria we can stick to?

Lots of questions, I know 😊 But hey that's why we are here....

Jazzis, Sep 8, 2005

+ #1



**innercircle**

Forum Resident

Location:

Monterrey, Mexico

Jazzis said:

*I wander what you think about that?*

*I have always felt a musical "freak" to some extent when chasing obscure and totally unpopular music, finding it the most challenging, meaningful and intellectually rewarding. My collection includes thousands of titles, which are rare and unfamiliar to most other people - and yet I consider*

[Click to expand...](#)

I've been asking the same thing. I mean for me the right answer could be NO! There are millions of Hip Hop fans over there, but I feel In My Own Personal Opinion this is not a good music, but in a thread here so good seller...so even when Jumbo doesn't I think it's a taste matter, dunno.

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innercircle, Sep 8, 2005

+ #2

**CM Wolff**

Senior Member

Location:  
Motown

Jazzis said:

*If a million people like a piece of music, does it mean it is "good" music?*

No, not directly. Quality is not a function of popularity. However, popularity can act as a indirect confirmation of quality. Attributes that can make music popular - catchy hooks, thoughtful lyrics, or something intangible that invokes an emotional response - are also often considered to be attributes of quality. In that regard, sometimes searching for quality in music appreciated by the masses can lead you to those attributes.

CM Wolff, Sep 8, 2005

+ #3

**Jazzis**

Forum Resident

Thread Starter

Location:  
Israel

innercircle said:

*I've been asking the same thing. I mean for me the right answer could be NO! There are millions of Hip Hop fans over there, but I feel In My Own Personal Opinion, this is not a good music, but in a thread here some told us that Pink Floyd is an excellent good seller...so even when Jumbo doesn't it, do no have to do bad.  
I think is a tastes matter, dunno.*

"It's all a matter of taste" is an easy way out of it.... 🤔 Of course I was hoping for some more elaborate rumblings on the subject.

Thanks anyway 🙌

Jazzis, Sep 8, 2005

+ #4

**innercircle**

Forum Resident

Location:  
Monterrey, Mexico

Jazzis said:

*"It's all a matter of taste" is an easy way out of it.... 🤔 Of course I was hoping for some more elaborate rumblings on the subject.*

Thanks anyway 🙌

Hi Jazzis. No I'm not trying to way out at the easy way. Is just that I think that some people does that the sells go up with their musical choices, even when I dislike their musical tastes. For me an excellent quality musician is Frank Zappa, but ask for his popularity in any country, and you might find some answers.  
Here in Mexico is a really minority whom knows at this genius, this not qualify at this musician. But ask for Shakira....and wow! the things changes. she is very popular here, and for me ( here is where the personal taste is ) she is awful!.

Regards!

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innercircle, Sep 8, 2005

+ #5

**grbl**

Just Lurking

Location:  
Long Island

Personally, I think there is no correlation. Much (but by no means not all) of what I listen to is not popular, and the vast majority of what is popular, I would personally not consider to be high quality. I would also argue, however, that quality is in the eye of the beholder. Just because I consider Mariah Carey's music (just one example) to be of poor quality, doesn't make it so.

The most popular recording artists of all time are the Beatles, which I would consider to be of very high quality. Of the top 10 recording artists of all time, I would personally only consider 5 or 6 to be of high quality. Of the top 10 albums of all time, I would personally only consider 3 to be of high quality. But again, that's just my personal opinion. Many here on this forum would disagree with my choices.

grbl, Sep 8, 2005

+ #6

**grbl**

Just Lurking

Location:  
Long Island

Jazzis said:

*"It's all a matter of taste" is an easy way out of it... 🙄 Of course I was hoping for some more elaborate rumblings on the subject.*

*Thanks anyway 🙌*

Unfortunately, I think that's the answer, though, unless you want to be elitist about it (which I've often been told that I am).

grbl, Sep 8, 2005

+ #7

**TheRealMcCoy**  
Senior MemberLocation:  
Chicago, IL

Your question can be related in the same way to the question "What is Art?" Musical quality is decided individually sometimes its popular sometimes not. To me its all about the listener determining the quality and everyone has different guidelines, points of reference, emotions... on what quality music is. Its really open ended thing.

Marko

TheRealMcCoy, Sep 8, 2005

+ #8

Here's one a lot don't agree with but I believe it.

If something sells, it's a success - and the

I love Randy Newman, but most don't. S

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**Captain Groovy**  
Senior Member

Location:  
Freedonia, USA

Britney Spears, because he's not able to catch the public's ear the way she does.

I do NOT believe there is ANY cosmic criteria for what's good and what's not. So if there is a better, it's a Britney Spears.

In some cases, like early Elton John and most of McCartney's career, I agree with the public.

I believe that if radio or other avenues of exposure were open to the Randys of the world, he would be slightly more popular, but not much.

I love him. I think he's brilliant. I love his voice. I love his lyrics. I love his melodic style. But I'm relatively alone.

I find it snobbish for people to say that Tom Waits is "better" than Christina Aguilera. There is no better - only popularity and opinions.

I'm sure that most will disagree on this point, but I have this discussion with people regarding movies all the time. I may like Woody Allen, but his films are not better than "Mr. and Mrs. Smith."

JEFF!

Captain Groovy, Sep 8, 2005

+ #9



**Jazzis**  
Forum Resident  
Thread Starter

Location:  
Israel

grbl said:

*Unfortunately, I think that's the answer, though, unless you want to be elitist about it (which I've often been told that I am).*

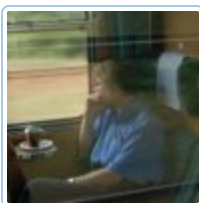
Nothing wrong with elitism - all in good measure of course.

The issue I'm trying to raise here is the existence of "objective" criteria to judge music by. So far we are in agreement popularity is NOT one of such criteria. But on the other hand saying that "it is all up to the person's taste" is simplistic at best.

And my question is NOT "what is Art" but "what is good Art".

Jazzis, Sep 8, 2005

+ #10



**Jazzis**

jeffbonie said:

*I'm sure that most will disagree on this point, but I have this discussion with people regarding movies all the time. I may like Woody Allen, but his films are not better than "Mr. and Mrs. Smith." JEFF!*

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Oh YES THEY ARE - infinitely better  another media - although we might draw parallels. BTW I love Randy too.

Forum Resident

Thread Starter

Jazzis, Sep 8, 2005

+ #11

Location:  
Israel**Wufnpoof**

Well-Known Member

Location:  
Boston, MA

Ultimately it's totally subjective as to whether a piece of music (or any artistic endeavor) is "good" or not. However, like-minded listeners may agree upon certain characteristics, or a set of standards, or some objective criteria, by which they judge the music's merit.

But the determinants for one group will probably be radically different from another. Some people really do feel that if it isn't popular, it isn't good.

I think most people have their own likes and dislikes which are fairly but not entirely consistent - I can't always explain why I like or dislike a song, I just do.

Wufnpoof, Sep 8, 2005

+ #12

**93curr**

Hyperactive!

Location:  
Toronto Ontario Canada

I always wonder just how "popular" popular music really is. I can remember, when I was a kid, my sister raving about some hit song she said was the greatest thing she'd ever heard (I think it was a single by Styx, or Queen or something). when I asked if she wanted the album as a birthday present she looked at me like I was nuts. she already bought the single, why would she want the album? well, because maybe there's other songs on it as good as the one she liked, I dared to suggest. (or, maybe even, the song she liked would sound even better framed in a larger context.) well, if they were any good, she'd hear them on the radio. (turns out, she'd never even bothered to listen to the b-side of the single she had.) besides, she didn't like albums. they were just too long. and the songs she liked, she only liked for awhile. by next month, she'd be bored of it and want something else.

needless to say, she always found the idea of anyone owning more than a dozen or so records downright psychotic.

at that point, I began to suspect that many (most, even) people didn't listen to music the way others did. maybe they get less out of it. maybe they just focus on the catchiest tune, and it doesn't have long-term appeal. maybe some people enjoy a nutritious, carefully cooked gourmet meal and other just eat candy and junk food and assume that those who subsist on gourmet dining aren't getting more from it than they are.

then I figured I was overthinking the whole thing and that what was important to one person didn't necessarily need to be of the same importance to everyone. plus, 99% of EVERYTHING the human race creates, from books to music to TV shows to potato chips, is pure crap. luckily, there's SO MUCH that any one person could absorb even the 1%

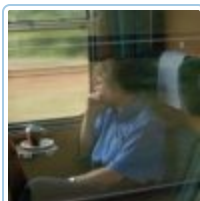
so, no. popularity is no measure of musical quality.

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people don't choose what music they listen to based on such criteria. or, often, any criteria at all beyond immediate sensory gratification.

93curr, Sep 8, 2005

+ #13



**Jazzis**

Forum Resident

Thread Starter

Location:

Israel

Wufnpoof said:

*Ultimately it's totally subjective as to whether a piece of music (or any artistic endeavor) is "good" or not. However, like-minded listeners may agree upon certain characteristics, or a set of standards, or some objective criteria, by which they judge the music's merit.*

*But the determinants for one group will probably be radically different from another. Some people really do feel that if it isn't popular, it isn't good.*

*I think most people have their own likes and dislikes which are fairly but not entirely consistent - I can't always explain why I like or dislike a song, I just do.*

Well if it's all "totally subjective", why is there a canon of music universally agreed upon as being "good" - let's say Bach, Bartok or Shostakovitch? Anybody claiming that music composed by those composers is "not good" would be ridiculed (and rightly so)?

Jazzis, Sep 8, 2005

+ #14



**BradOlson**

Country/Christian Music Maven

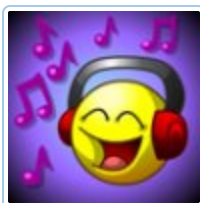
Location:

Bemidji, Minnesota, USA

In the same manor, I, and many here, think Joe South is a very talented artist but the general public is only familiar with a couple of his singles even though most of his signature songs as a writer and an artist appear on "Introspect" and "Don't It Make You Want To Go Home," with both albums in my book and many others here, being classics. The major critics have always agreed with me, the same with many artists. Most people who listen to commercial country radio, go to dances, etc. prefer Shania Twain over Kitty Wells while although I do have some Shania CDs, I prefer Kitty Wells's music over Shania. I know that many people in the forum prefer listening to Kitty's music as well.

BradOlson, Sep 8, 2005

+ #15



**Mike B**

Forum Resident

Location:

New York City

Terms like "quality" and "good" and all that vary from person to person so much that they lose all meaning.

The only term I think has any merit is "honesty," which is difficult for me to define anyway.

Mike B, Sep 8, 2005

+ #16

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**BradOlson**Country/Christian  
Music MavenLocation:  
Bemidji, Minnesota, USA

Mike B said:

*Terms like "quality" and "good" and all that vary from person to person so much that they lose all meaning.*

*The only term I think has any merit is "honesty," which is difficult for me to define anyway.*

You are right.

BradOlson, Sep 8, 2005

+ #17

**Captain Groovy**

Senior Member

Location:  
Freedonia, USA

Mike B said:

*The only term I think has any merit is "honesty," which is difficult for me to define anyway.*

Remind me not to buy anything off you in the Classifieds section. Just kidding...

JEFF!

Captain Groovy, Sep 8, 2005

+ #18

**Wufnpoo**

Well-Known Member

Location:  
Boston, MA

Jazzis said:

*Well if it's all "totally subjective", why is there a canon of music universall agreed upon as being "good" - let's say Bach, Bartok or Shostakovitch? Anybody claiming that music composed by those composers is "not good" would be ridiculed (and rightly so)?*

Hi Adam. Unfortunately, here in the US, I'm not sure that's true. 😞

There's less and less interest in classical music here. Even among its listeners, I would say that most can only say what they like and don't like (ie: they don't have enough knowledge to make an "objective" assessment). And I know quite a few people who are educated in classical music who might try to argue that Shostakovitch isn't good (although I'd disagree with them).

Musicians and listeners who are knowledgeable about a given area of music (such as classical, jazz, popular, or any smaller sub-category within these areas) may agree on standards by which this work can be judged as "good" (or "great"). But I think it's pretty meaningless to acknowledge something as "great" unless you actually like it, in which case it comes down ultimately to some kind of subjective judgement.

For me, I'm not conscious of just plugging a mechanism that evaluates a piece of music on its own qualities to determine whether it's "good" or "bad". A piece of music or performance is affected by many things that may have nothing to do

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with the music itself - my mood, my ability to concentrate, the circumstances in which I'm hearing the music, etc.

What I try to do is listen for what's there - to appreciate a piece of music or a performance on it's own terms as much as possible. That doesn't necessarily mean I'm going to like or understand everything I hear - I find some pieces to offer more than others, and some performances to be more inspiring than others. But even in cases where I can put my reasons for this into words, it would be futile for me to argue that everyone should acquiesce in my evaluation.

Wufnpoof said:

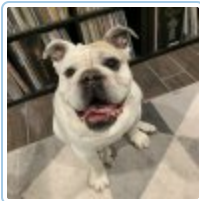
*[...]there's less and less interest in classical music here. Even among its listeners, I would say that most can only say what they like and don't like (ie: they don't have enough knowledge to make an "objective" assessment).*

By the way, I guess this sounds snobbish but I didn't mean it to. I really do believe that "all you need is ears." It also helps to have an open mind - and while trusting your own judgement, not to assume that it's the ultimate measure of what is good and what isn't.

Those listeners who take enough of an interest in classical music to familiarize themselves with a large body of work, and who study the music in order to understand the qualities that make it "great," are going to be better able to argue in objective terms why Bach, Bartok, Shostokovich or any other composer is great (or not).

Wufnpoof, Sep 8, 2005

+ #19



#### Pug

The Prodigal Snob Returns!

Location:  
Near Music Direct

Jazzis said:

*Well if it's all "totally subjective", why is there a canon of music universally agreed upon as being "good" - let's say Bach, Bartok or Shostakovitch? Anybody claiming that music composed by those composers is "not good" would be ridiculed (and rightly so)?*

Look at an album like Pet Sounds. We all regard it as a classic here but it was never a big seller, especially when it was first released.

Pug, Sep 8, 2005

+ #20



I've edited my previous post to clarify what I meant - it could be construed as elitist (and maybe it is, but I didn't mean to sound like such a snob).

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Wufnpoof, Sep 8, 2005

+ #21



**Wufnpoof**

Well-Known Member

Location:  
Boston, MA**Jazzis**

Forum Resident

Thread Starter

Location:  
Israel

Wufnpoof said:

Hi Adam. Unfortunately, here in the US, I'm not sure that's true. 🙄

*There's less and less interest in classical music here. Even among its listeners, I would say that most can only say what they like and don't like (ie: they don't have enough knowledge to make an "objective" assessment). And I know quite a few people who are educated in classical music who might try to argue that*

*Click to expand...*

Thanks for a great response (am I able to evaluate that 🤖)?

Here are some points:

I'm not talking about an algorithm to evaluate music - input a piece of music - output a grade 🤖

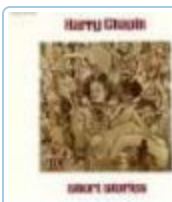
But about that "internal mechanism" - well your brain is certainly one and your music appreciation comes from your brain, not your ears (contrary to the popular belief 🤖). So when you listen your brain is making a judgment of quality (in parallel to the pleasure part) - like it or not.

Now what criteria is your brain using? Well, it's quite complex (I could point you to some books on the subject), but surely your education - musical and otherwise - and your cultural background play a role here, as does your intelligence and intellectual capacity.

Appreciating music does (sometimes, not always) mean "understanding" it - rhythm, harmony, scales, improvisation, polyrhythmics, layers of sound, etc., etc. - all those things are pawn on the chess board called a piece of music. If you are familiar with the rules of the game you are able to play it - so to speak.

Jazzis, Sep 8, 2005

+ #22

**mrtanner**

Jazzis said:

*yet I consider them "better" musically than all the "popular" stuff.*

*If a million people like a piece of music, does it*

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Active Member

Location:

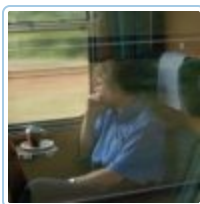
A Town in the Midwest

If you use popularity as a measure of quality and therefore the most popular is regarded as factually, "The best", then the best restaurant around is McDonald's. The best car in the world used to be the Ford Escort and now would probably the Toyota Camry. The best author of the last century would be JK Rowling. And the best pizza in the U.S. would have to come from Pizza Hut.

While all of these things are the most popular and all have certain merits, very few people would argue that they are the absolute best in their category.

mrtanner, Sep 8, 2005

+ #23

**Jazzis**

Forum Resident

Thread Starter

Location:

Israel

zloch1 said:

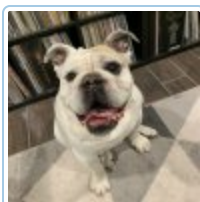
*Look at an album like Pet Sounds. We all regard it as a classic here but it was never a big seller, especially when it was first released.*

It was a big seller as the Beach Boys were at the peak of their popularity.

It's classic "statue" arrived much later of course, regardless of the sales volume and based on the merits of the work itself - and rightfully so - although the comparison to the Beatles and the whole "noise" about it was totally out of place. If you read Brian's book you will see what I mean.

Jazzis, Sep 8, 2005

+ #24

**Pug**

The Prodigal Snob Returns!

Location:

Near Music Direct

Jazzis said:

*It was a big seller as the Beach Boys were at the peak of their popularity.*

Pet Sounds didn't go Gold until 2000. It didn't sell as well as its predecessor.

Pug, Sep 8, 2005

+ #25

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